

CANADA VS SOUTH AFRICA

Round of 32 opposition report: South Africa tactical profile, match data and Canada response.

MATCH LENS

South Africa is flexible: compact without the ball, patient enough to build through midfield and dangerous when wide releases or central rotations create the next forward pass. Canada must protect the half-spaces and prevent repeat circulation.

3

PMSR GAMES

World Cup group

20

TEAM ROWS

last calendar year

3

GROUP ROWS

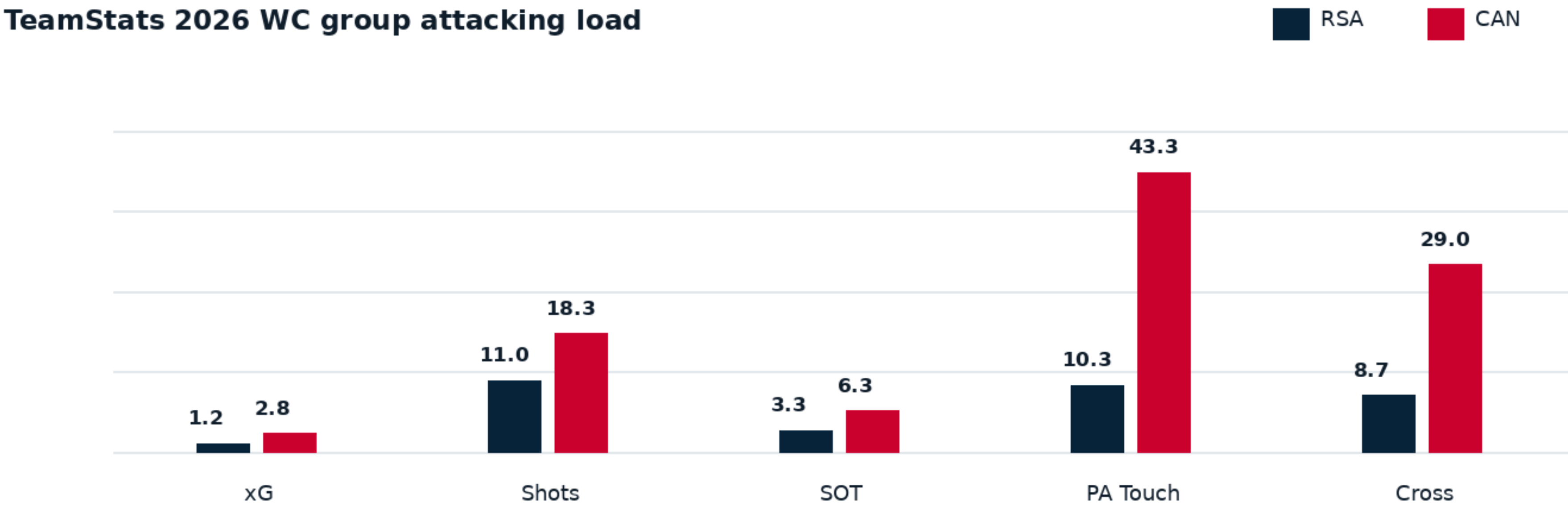
TeamStats

14

RSA PLAYERS

player file

TeamStats 2026 WC group attacking load



TeamStats World Cup group sample; player-data pages isolate role-specific threats.

SOUTH AFRICA MATCH THEMES

- Stable first phase: build-up can use a wide base with a midfielder dropping to connect play.
- Compact mid-block: South Africa can defend narrow, screen central spaces and force slower wide circulation.
- Transition release: the first forward pass after regains is a threat, especially when Canada lose the ball with full-backs advanced.
- Final-third pattern: wide service, cutbacks and second actions remain the main attacking routes.

CANADA GAME READ

- Do not chase every pass in South Africa circulation; press when the ball is forced wide or played backward.
- Keep the midfield screen tight around the dropping connector and deny the easy bounce pass into the No. 10 zone.
- Use Buchanan and Laryea speed early before South Africa recover into their compact block.
- When defending the box, protect the cutback lane and clear second balls outside the central shooting zone.

KEY MATCH INDICATORS

84%

PASS COMPLETION

supports build-up stability

28.7

PRESSURES

compact block still creates pressure

11.0

SHOTS

can turn territory into attempts

7.9

MAX XA

creative output concentrated in key players

PROJECTED LINEUPS & AVAILABILITY

Canada 4-4-2 against South Africa 4-2-3-1, with role logic tied to the player-data sample.

CANADA PROJECTED XI (4-4-2)



CANADA NOTE

- Wide pairs must protect both first duel and recovery space.
- Eustaquio/Saliba screen Mofokeng before jumping wide.
- David/Larin give Canada a central outlet against a compact block.

SOUTH AFRICA PROJECTED XI (4-2-3-1)



SOUTH AFRICA ROLE NOTE

- Mofokeng connects midfield to attack and carries strong xA output.
- Appollis/Maseko are the wide transition threats.
- Makgopa/Rayners/Foster profiles give box and second-ball reference points.

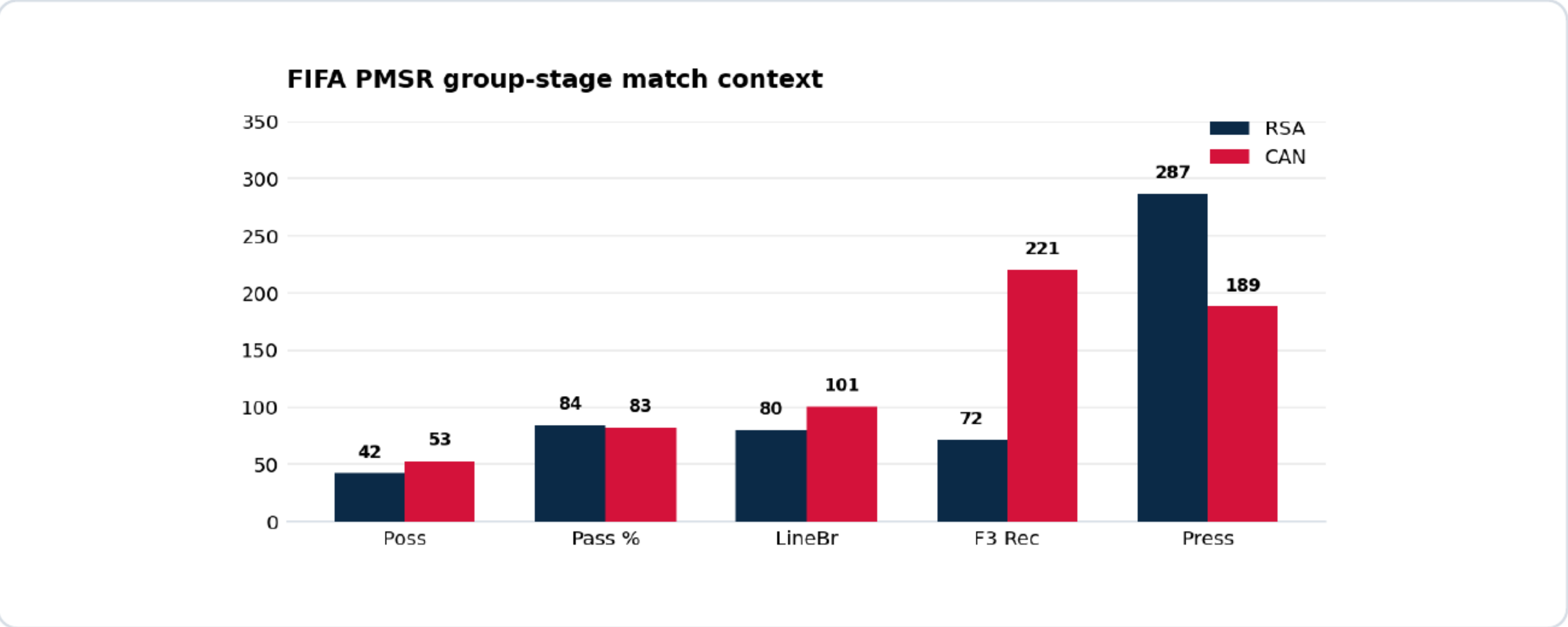
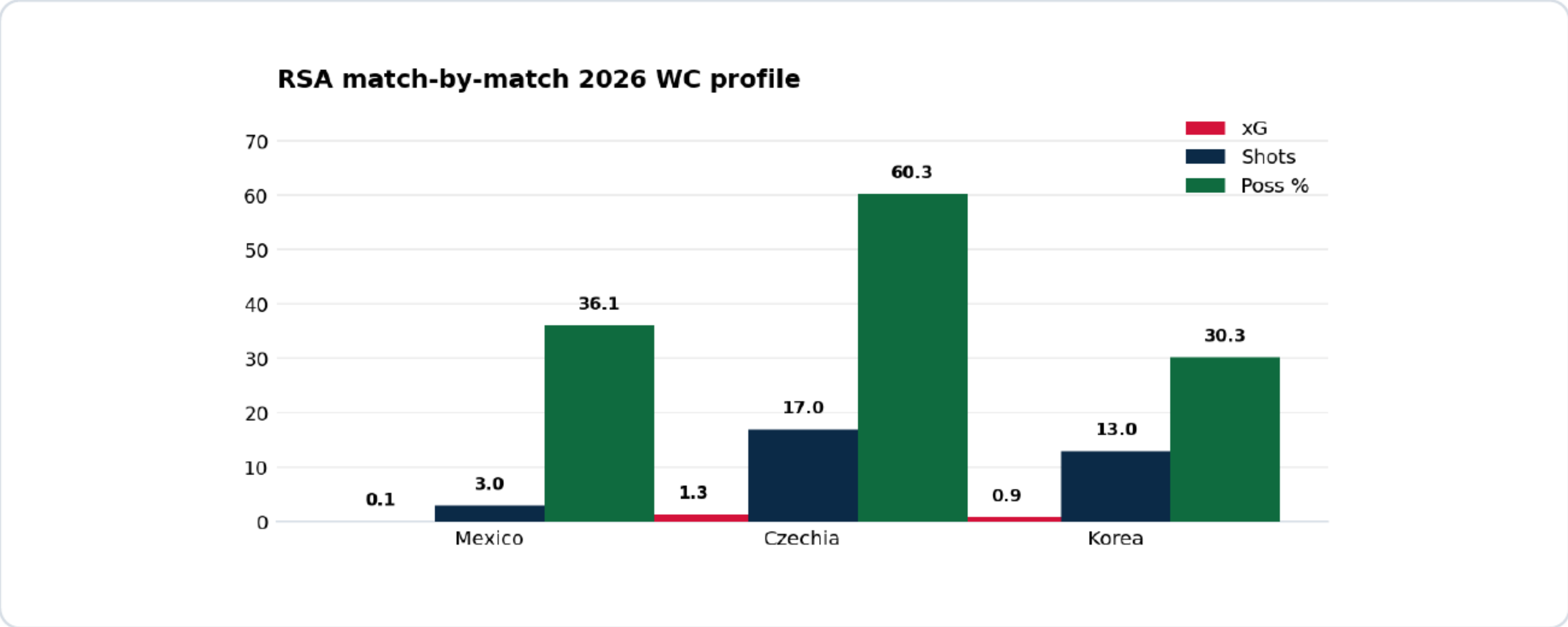
PLAYER-DATA REASON FOR THE SHAPE

Player	Role	Output sample	Canada read
Mofokeng	AM/LAMF	10 G / 7.2 xA	between-line creator
Appollis	RAMF/LAMF	13 G / 10.3 xG	direct wide scorer
Modiba	LB	7 A / 7.9 xA	left-side delivery
Makgopa	CF	8.5 xG	box reference

WORLD CUP MATCH SAMPLE

Three South Africa group games: PMSR match context plus TeamStats model outputs.

Match	PMSR xG	PMSR Poss	PMSR Press	TeamStats xG	TS Shots	TS PPDA	Read
MEX 2-0 RSA	0.10	36.1%	306	0.14	3	28.1	limited attack; forced to defend
CZE 1-1 RSA	1.34	60.3%	233	1.77	17	14.1	controlled ball and line breaks
RSA 1-0 KOR	0.89	30.3%	321	1.84	13	21.7	lower-possession win through pressure



SAMPLE READ

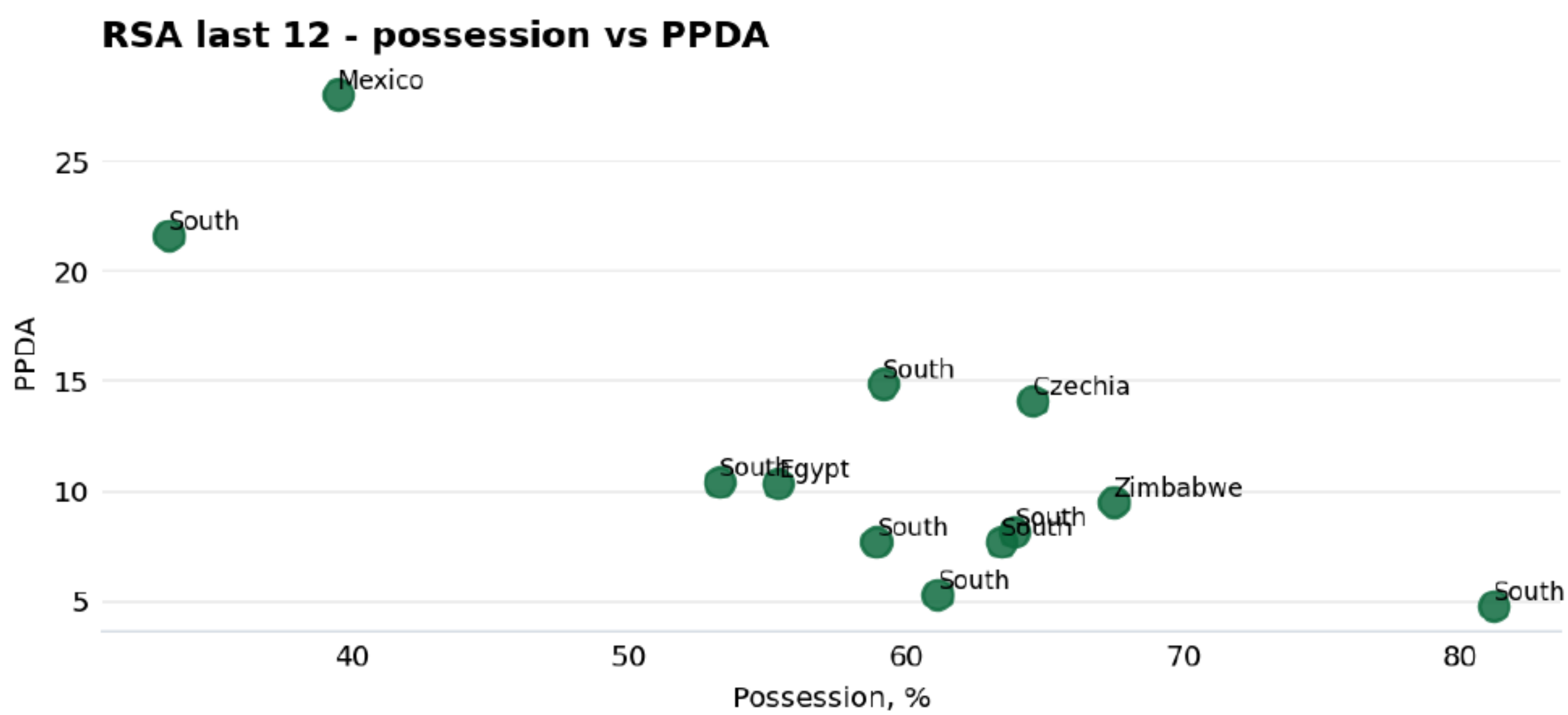
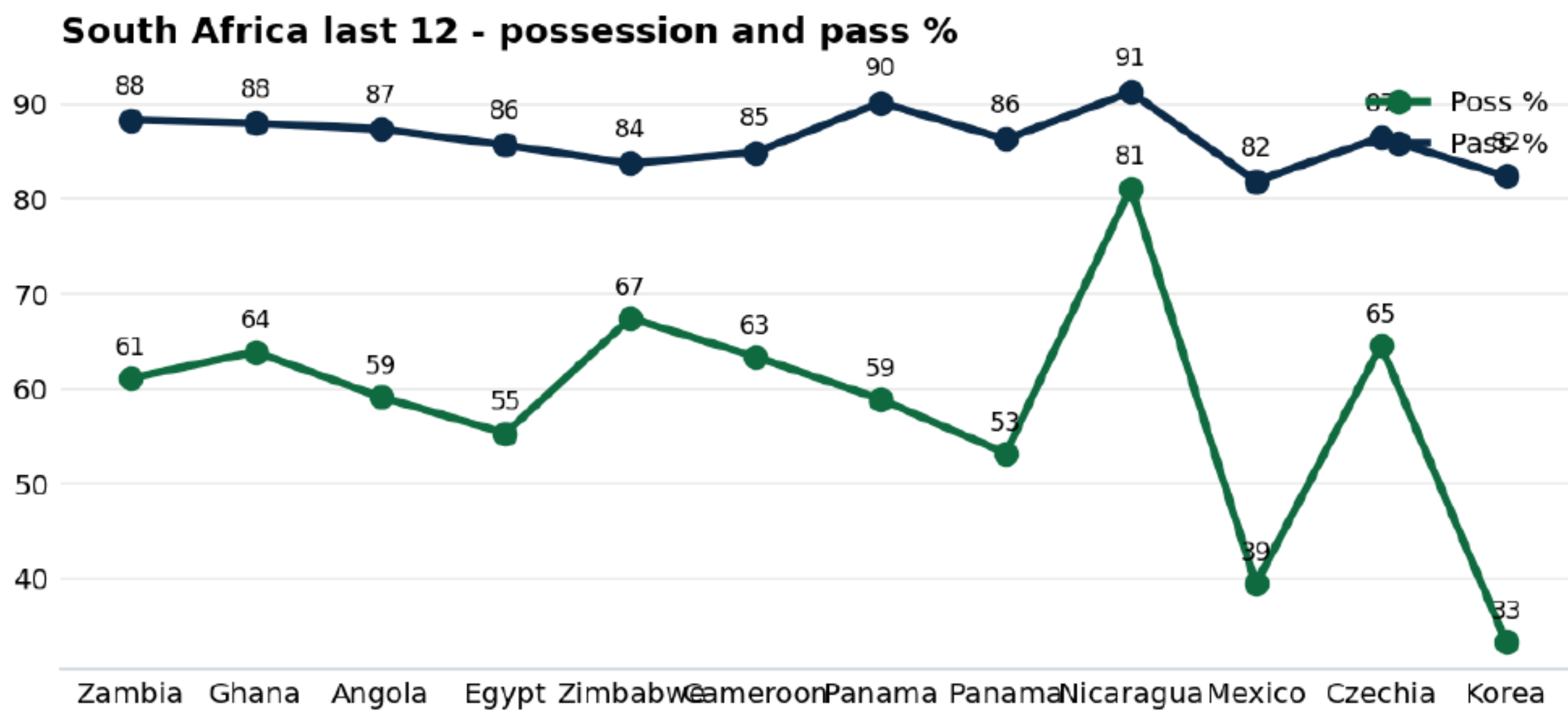
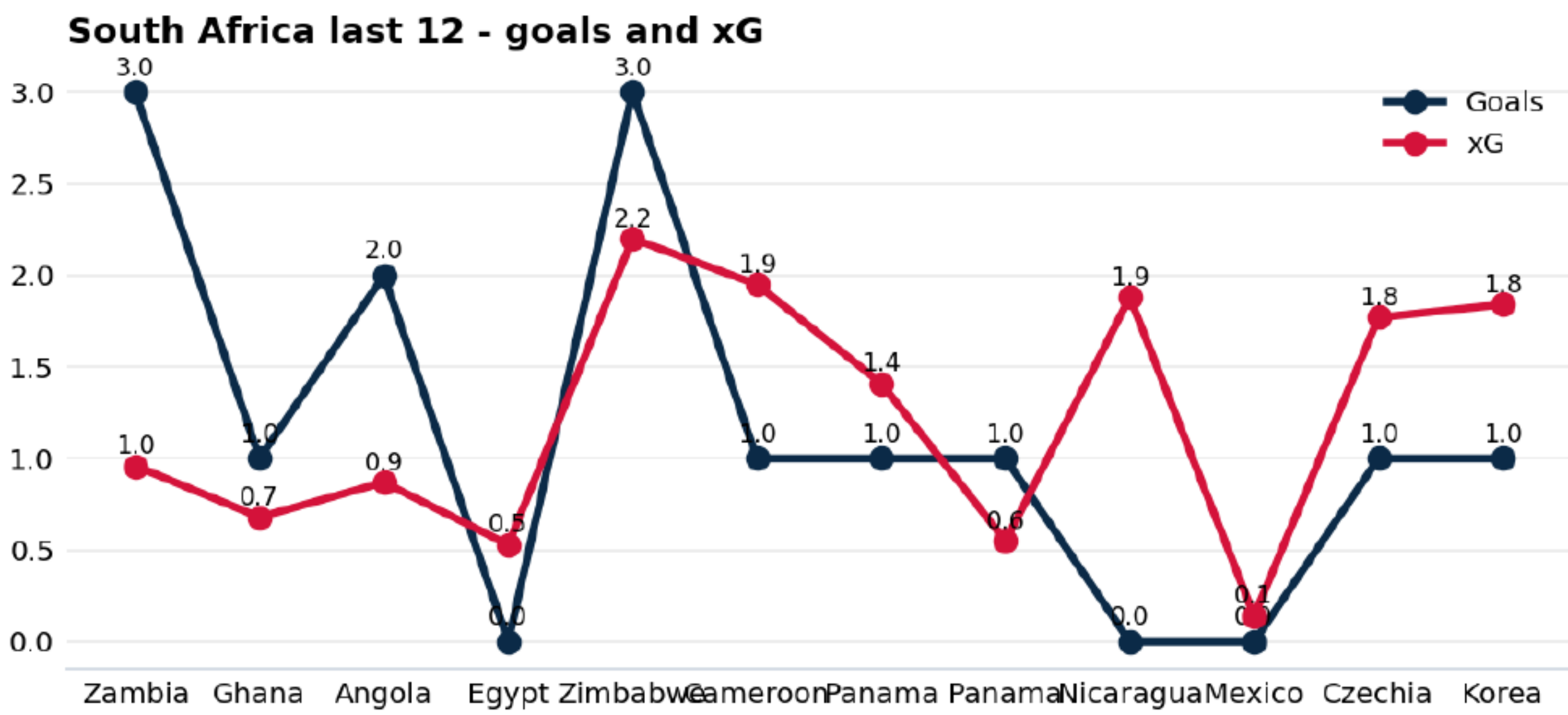
- South Africa’s data is not one fixed profile: possession range shifts from 30.3% to 60.3% in the PMSR group sample.
- The Korea win shows defensive/transition behavior: 321 pressures, 40 forced turnovers and 68 second balls.
- The Czechia draw supports build-up control: 584 passes, 89% pass completion and 114 line breaks.

CANADA IMPLICATION

- Prepare for both versions: controlled build-up and lower-possession transition game.
- Do not let the match become repeated second-ball defending after Canada loses possession.
- First pass after regain is a critical stabilizer against their counter-press/compact block.

RECENT FORM TREND DATA

Last-calendar-year TeamStats sample: xG, goals, possession, pass completion and PPDA patterns.



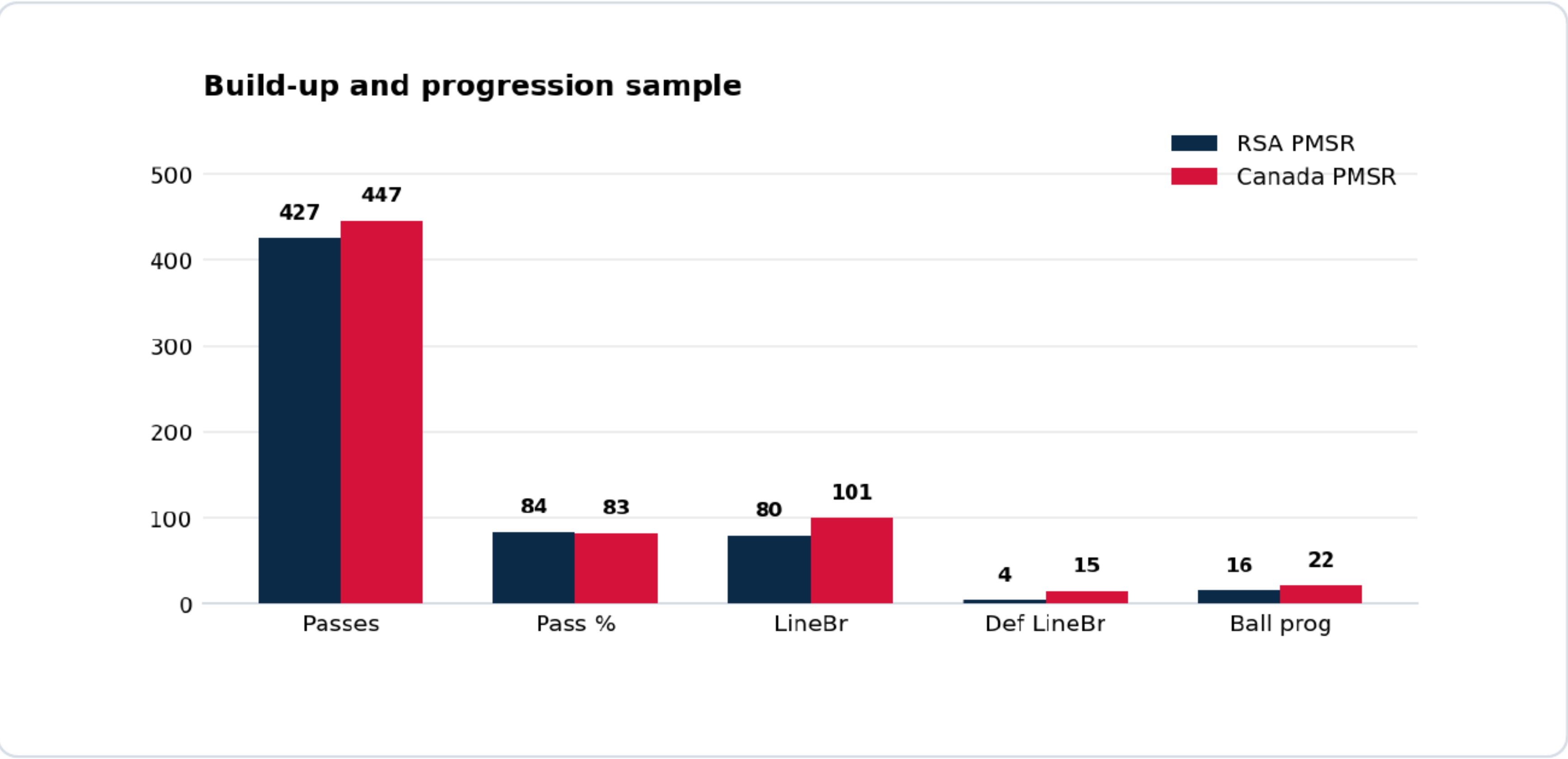
Date	Match	G	xG	Shots	Poss %	PPDA
2025-12-29	Zimbabwe - South Africa 2:3	3.0	2.20	15.0	67.5	9.5
2026-01-04	South Africa - Cameroon 1:2	1.0	1.95	16.0	63.4	7.7
2026-03-27	South Africa - Panama 1:1	1.0	1.41	11.0	58.9	7.7
2026-03-31	South Africa - Panama 1:2	1.0	0.55	7.0	53.2	10.4
2026-05-29	South Africa - Nicaragua 0:0	0.0	1.88	22.0	81.2	4.8
2026-06-11	Mexico - South Africa 2:0	0.0	0.14	3.0	39.5	28.1
2026-06-18	Czechia - South Africa 1:1	1.0	1.77	17.0	64.6	14.1
2026-06-25	South Africa - Korea Republic 1:0	1.0	1.84	13.0	33.4	21.7

TREND INTERPRETATION

- South Africa’s last-year output shows several possession-control games, but the World Cup group sample proves they can also win without the ball.
- Canada should not overfit to one phase: the match plan must cover build-up pressure, mid-block patience and transition defence.

BUILD-UP STRUCTURE: DATA SUPPORT

The build-up image is supported by pass volume, pass completion and line-break samples.



EVIDENCE FROM DATA

- PMSR average: 427 passes, 84% completion and 80 completed line breaks.
- Czechia game shows the high-control version: 584 passes, 89% completion and 114 line breaks.
- Korea game shows the lower-possession version: only 345 passes but still 69 line breaks and 21 ball progressions.

CANADA PRESSING RESPONSE

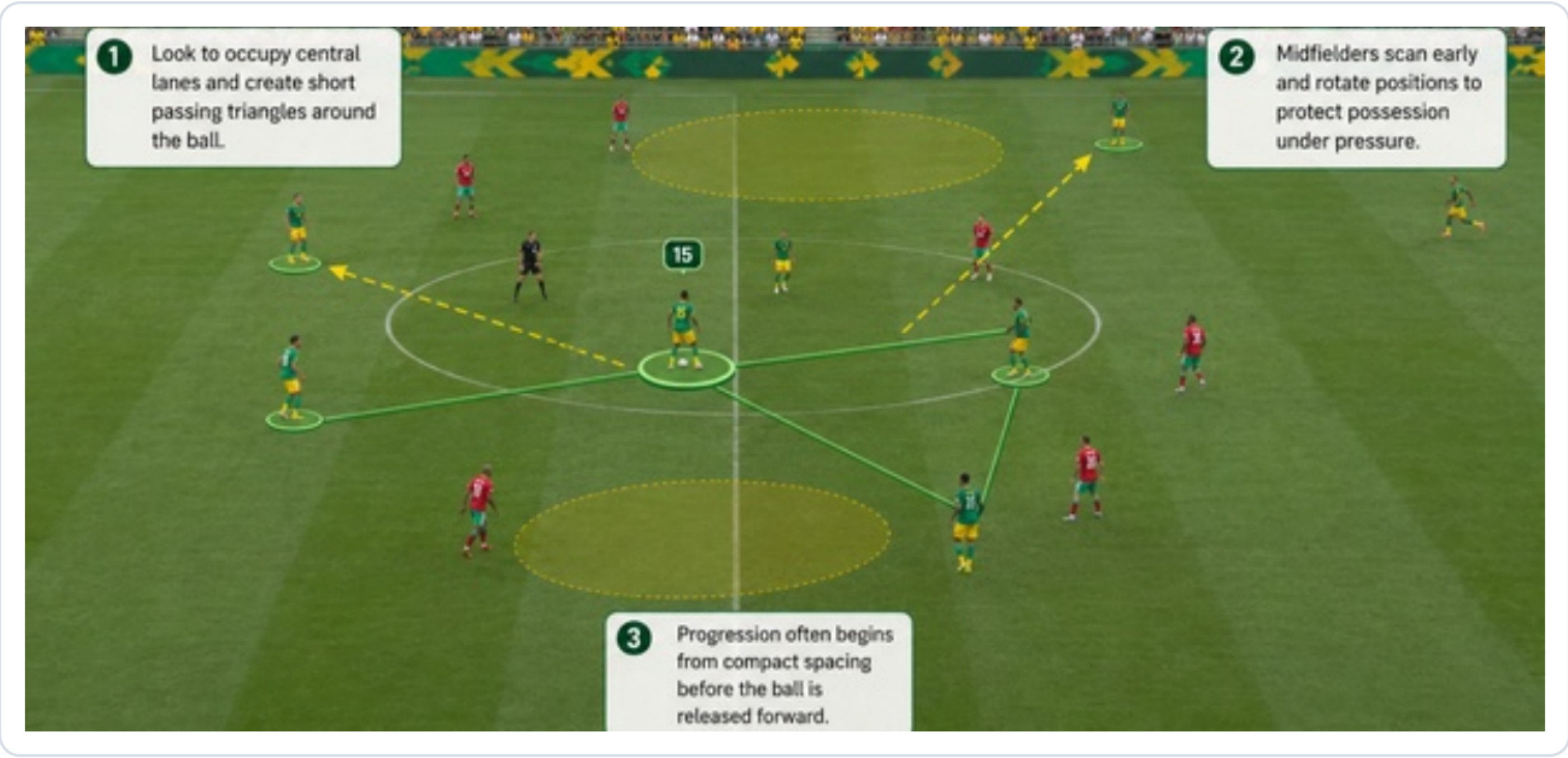
- Do not chase all circulation; set pressing traps when their central midfielder receives facing own goal.
- Keep a screen on Mofokeng/No.10 space while wide pressure jumps.
- If South Africa play short, the goal is to force long release into Canada’s centre-backs and second-ball structure.

BUILD-UP CLAIM

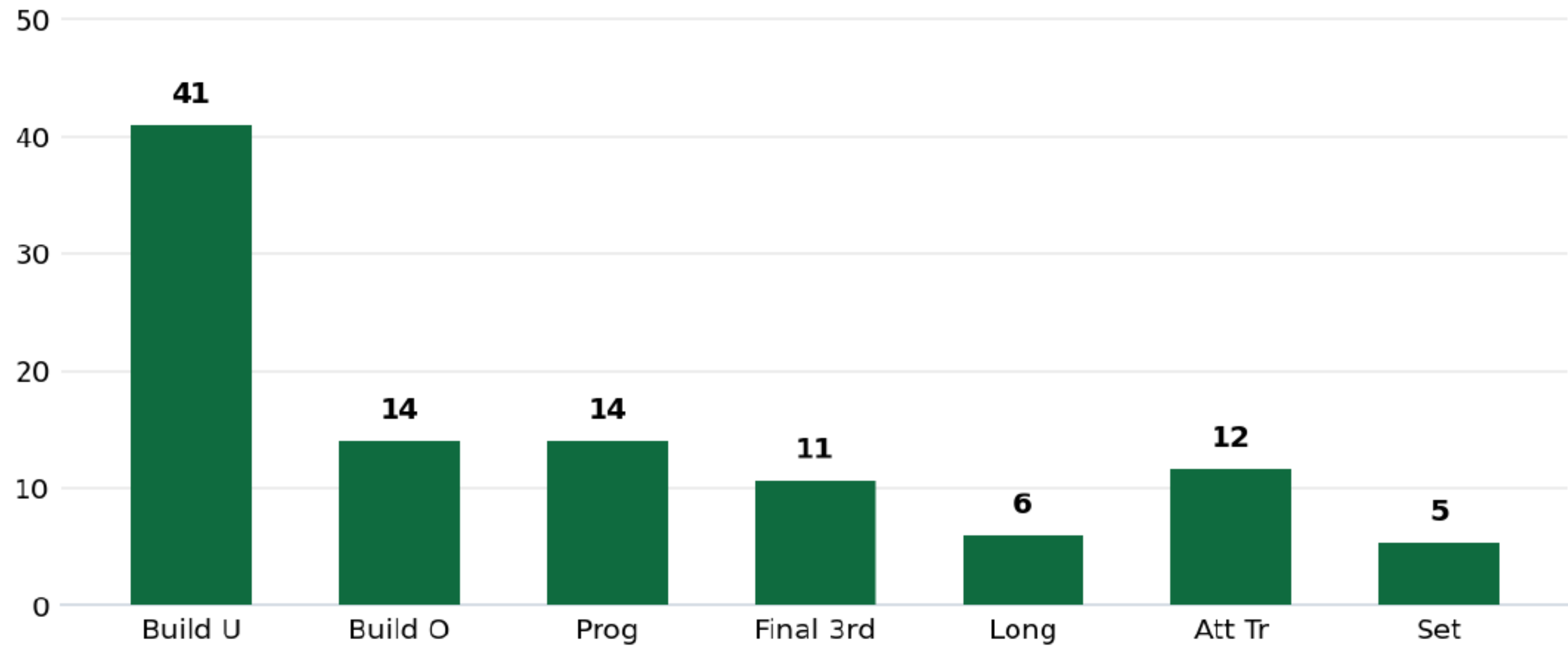
The image shows a stable first-phase base, but the data shows the base is flexible rather than possession-only. South Africa can use the same structure to circulate, draw pressure, or create a direct exit.

MIDFIELD CONTROL & PROGRESSION

Central rotations and line-breaking are backed by both PMSR and last-year TeamStats.



RSA FIFA PMSR in-possession phase average



Metric	RSA sample	Why it matters
PMSR line breaks	80	Shows ability to progress through or around the block.
PMSR ball progressions	16	Supports controlled carries/passes into next phase.
TeamStats progressive passes	57.3	Broader event data: progressive passing supply.
TeamStats final-third passes	49.0	Measures supply into attacking zones.
TeamStats PPDA	21.3	Pressure profile: they can sit deeper than Canada.

CANADA MIDFIELD KEYS

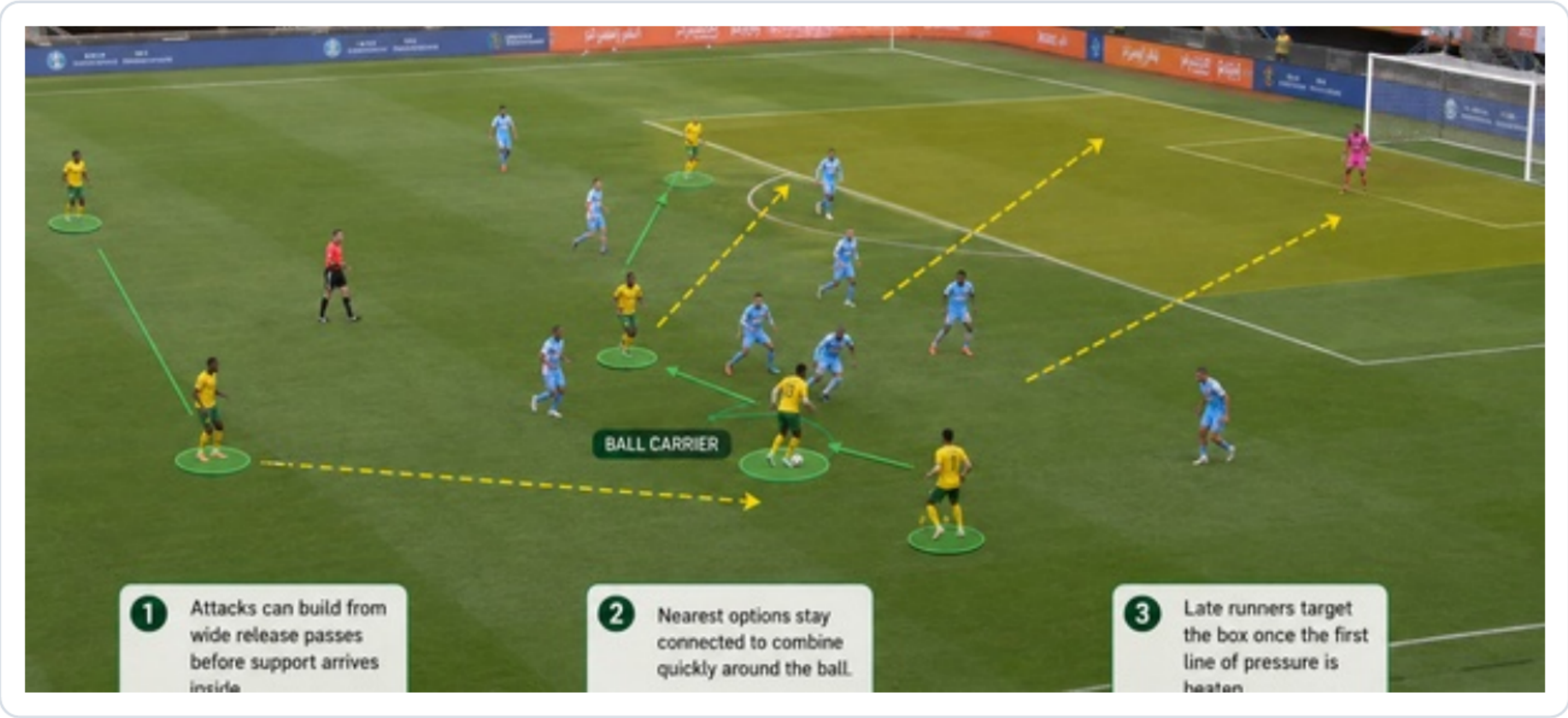
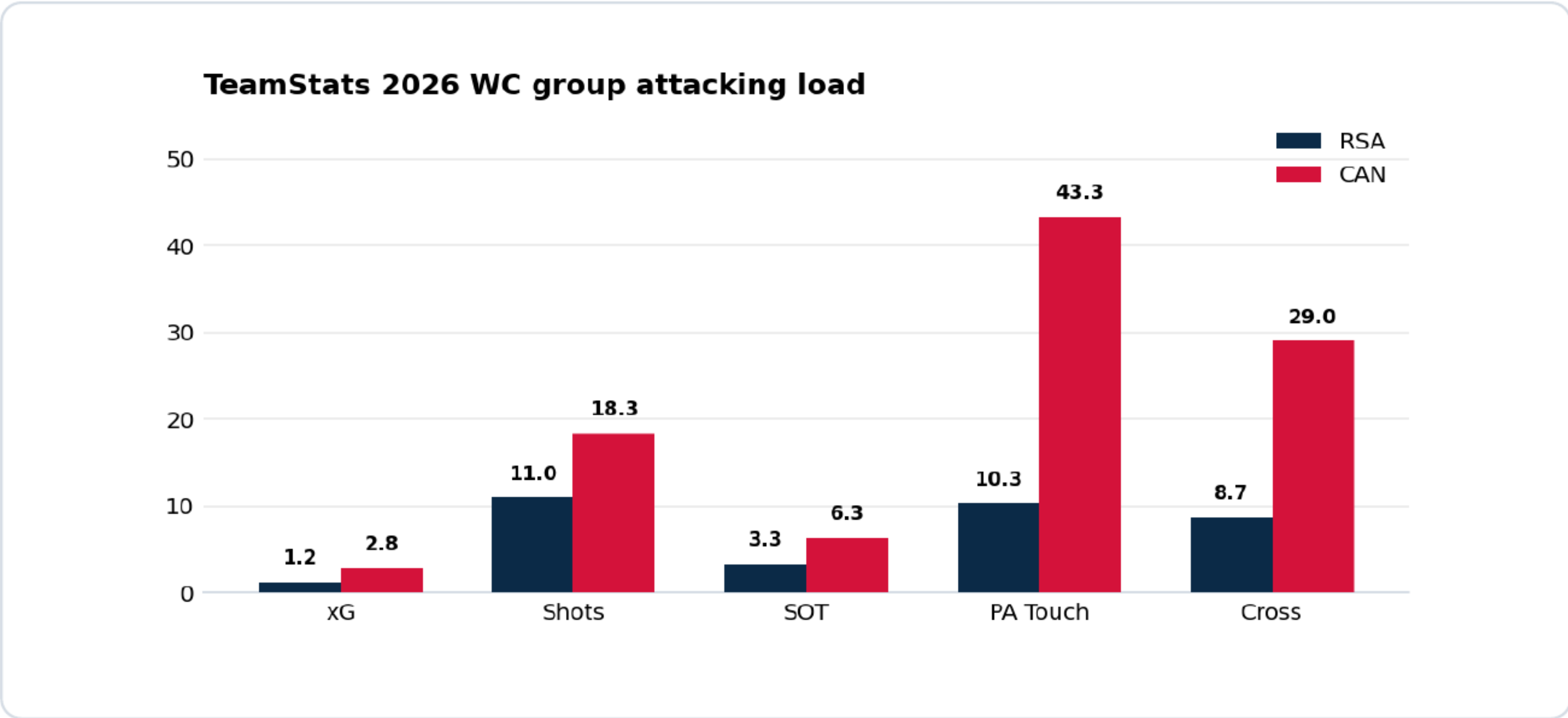
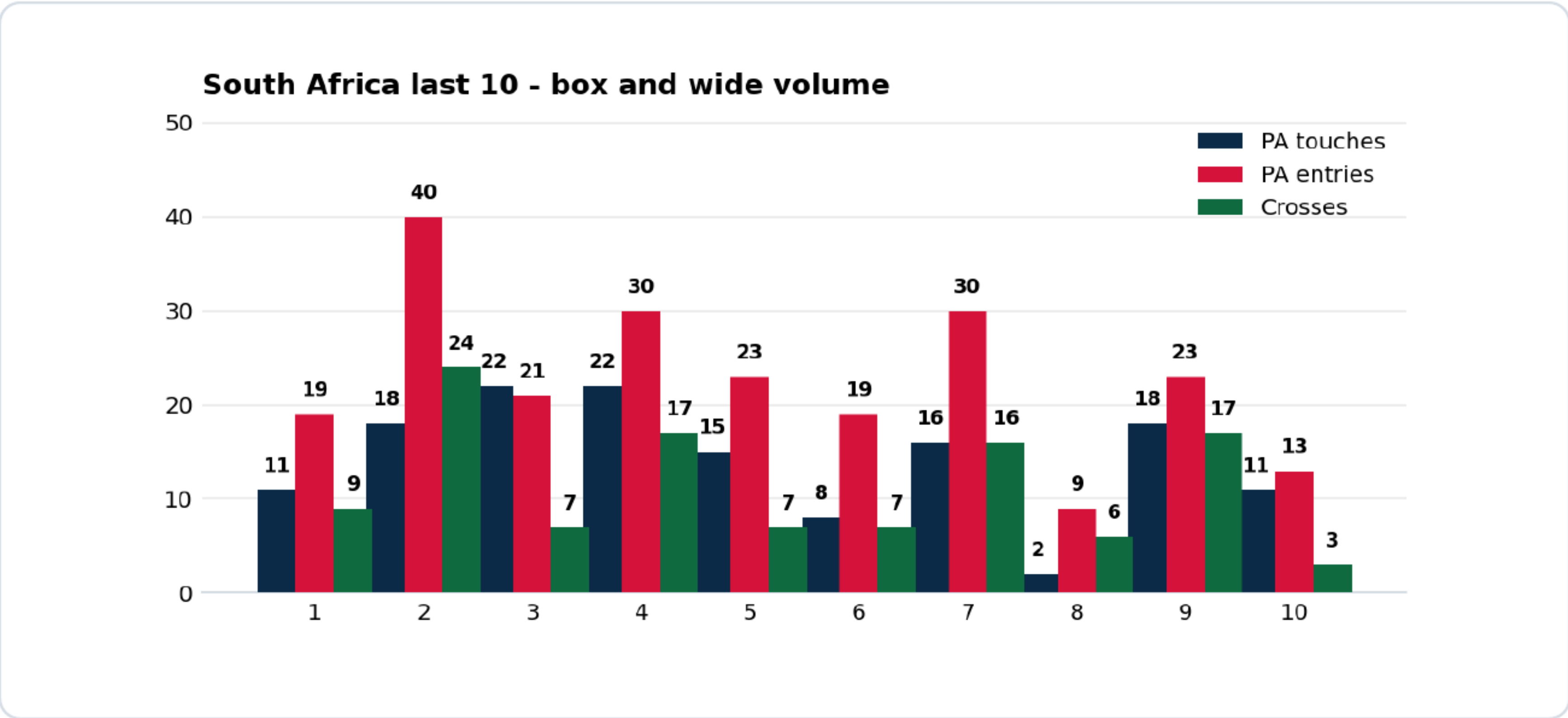
- Eustaquio and Saliba cannot both jump beyond the ball; one must keep the screen.
- First Canadian pressure must angle South Africa away from the central No.10 pocket.
- If Canada regain centrally, first pass should be forward or wide before the counter-press arrives.

TACTICAL READ

The midfield-control graphic is not decorative: it explains how South Africa protect possession with short triangles, while the line-break and progressive-pass data explains why Canada must protect central lanes before pressing wide.

SOUTH AFRICA ATTACKING PROFILE

Graph-driven view of wide release, box pressure and player-role threat.



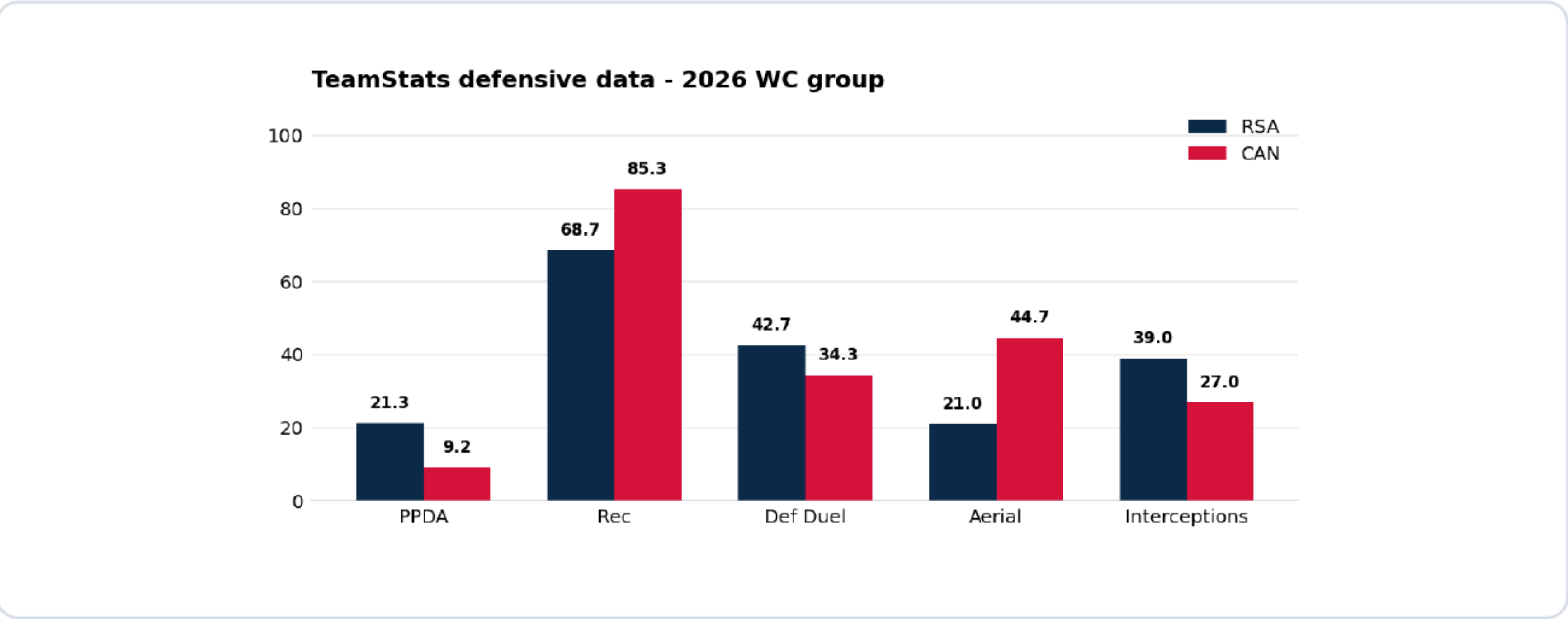
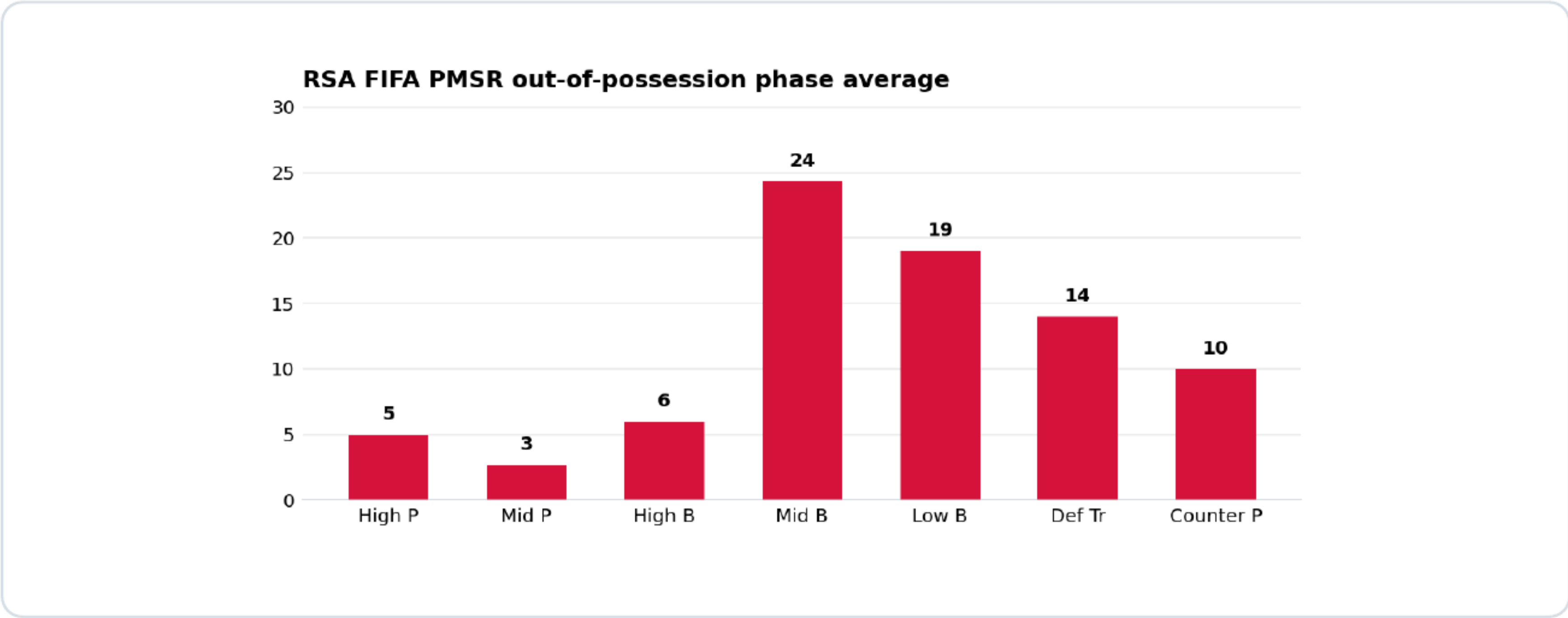
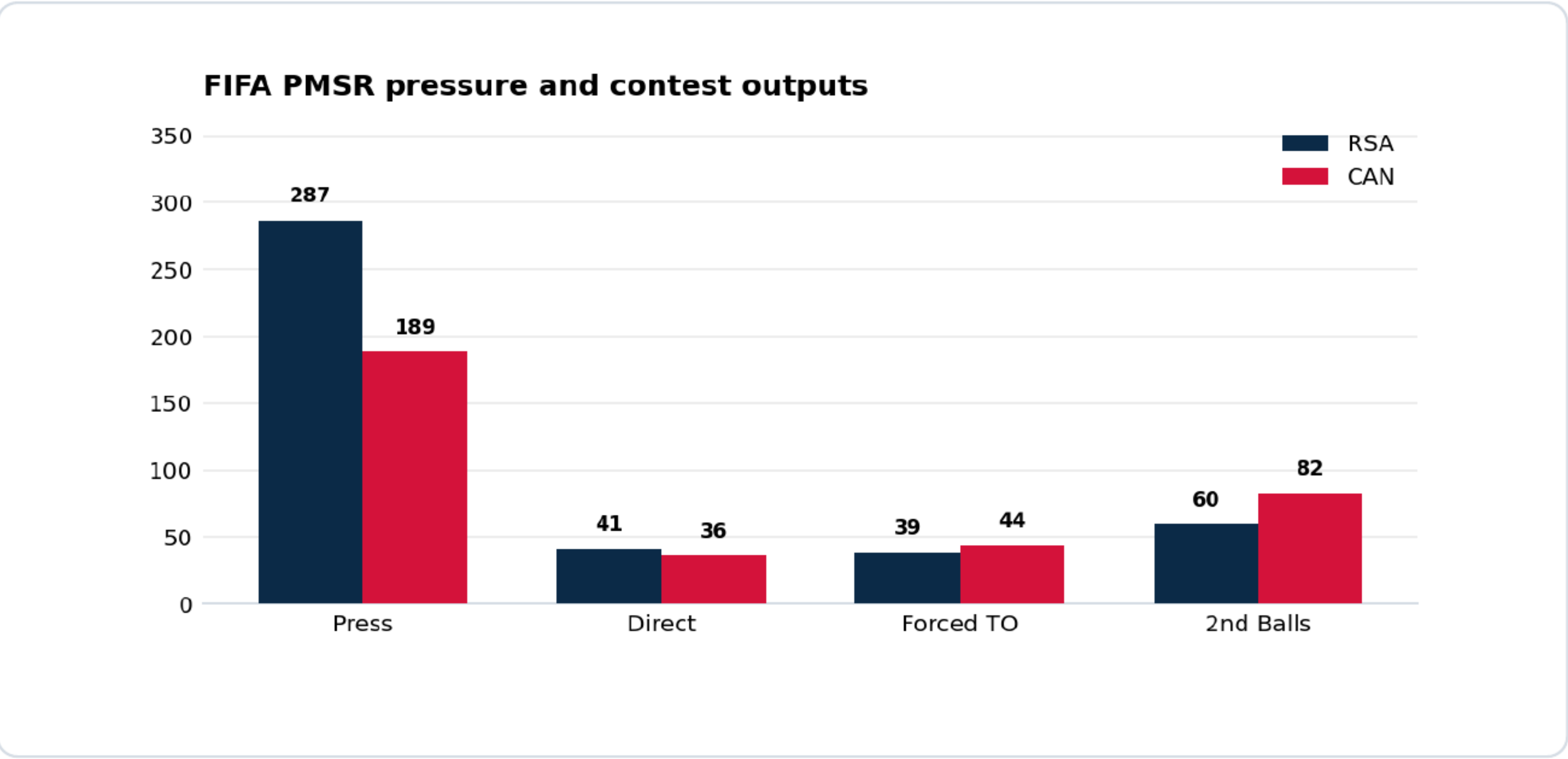
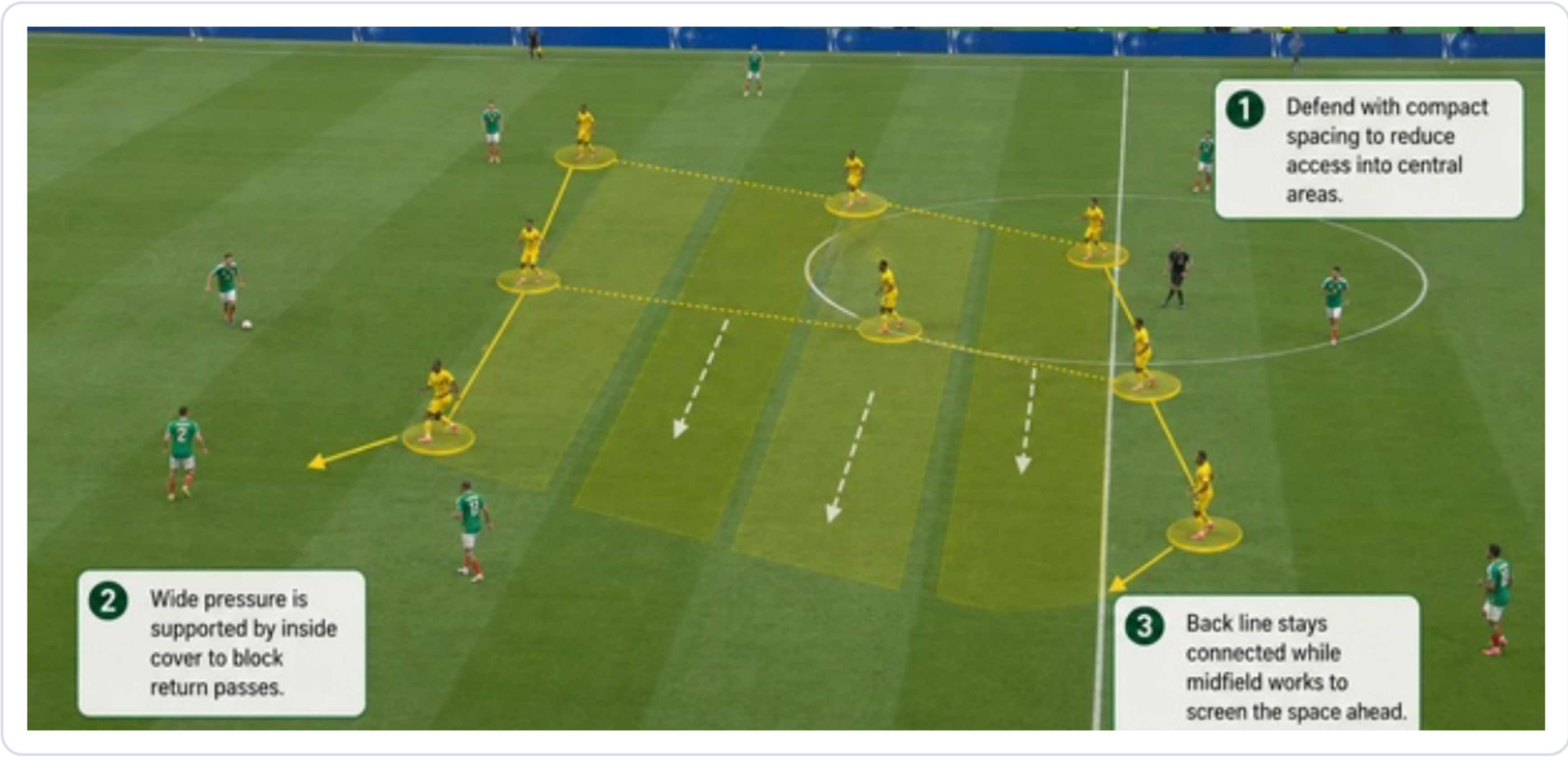
Metric	Sample value	Canada implication
xG	0.78 PMSR 1.25 TeamStats	chance volume varies by source/model; both show RSA can ge...
Shots	11.0 PMSR 11.0 TeamStats	Canada must prevent repeat shots after first action
Crosses	10.3 PMSR 8.7 TeamStats	wide service remains a route, but not always high volume
PA touches	10.3 TeamStats	box occupation is the key final-third read

ATTACKING PATTERN READ

The attack should be treated as wide release plus connected support, not isolated crossing. Canada need to manage the first wide duel, then track the second runner and cutback zone.

DEFENSIVE SHAPE & PRESSING DATA

The defensive image is supported by pressure volume, forced turnovers, PPDA and block-phase data.

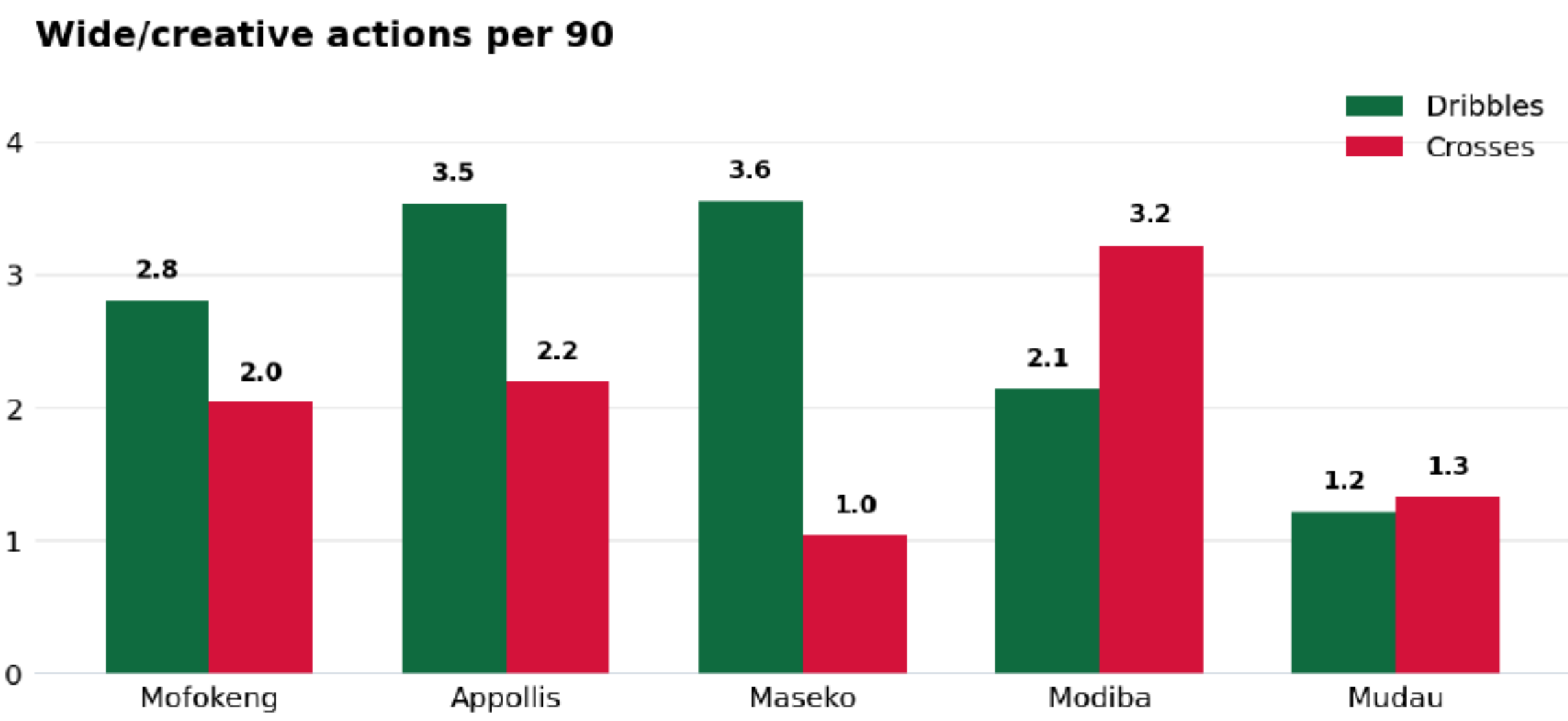
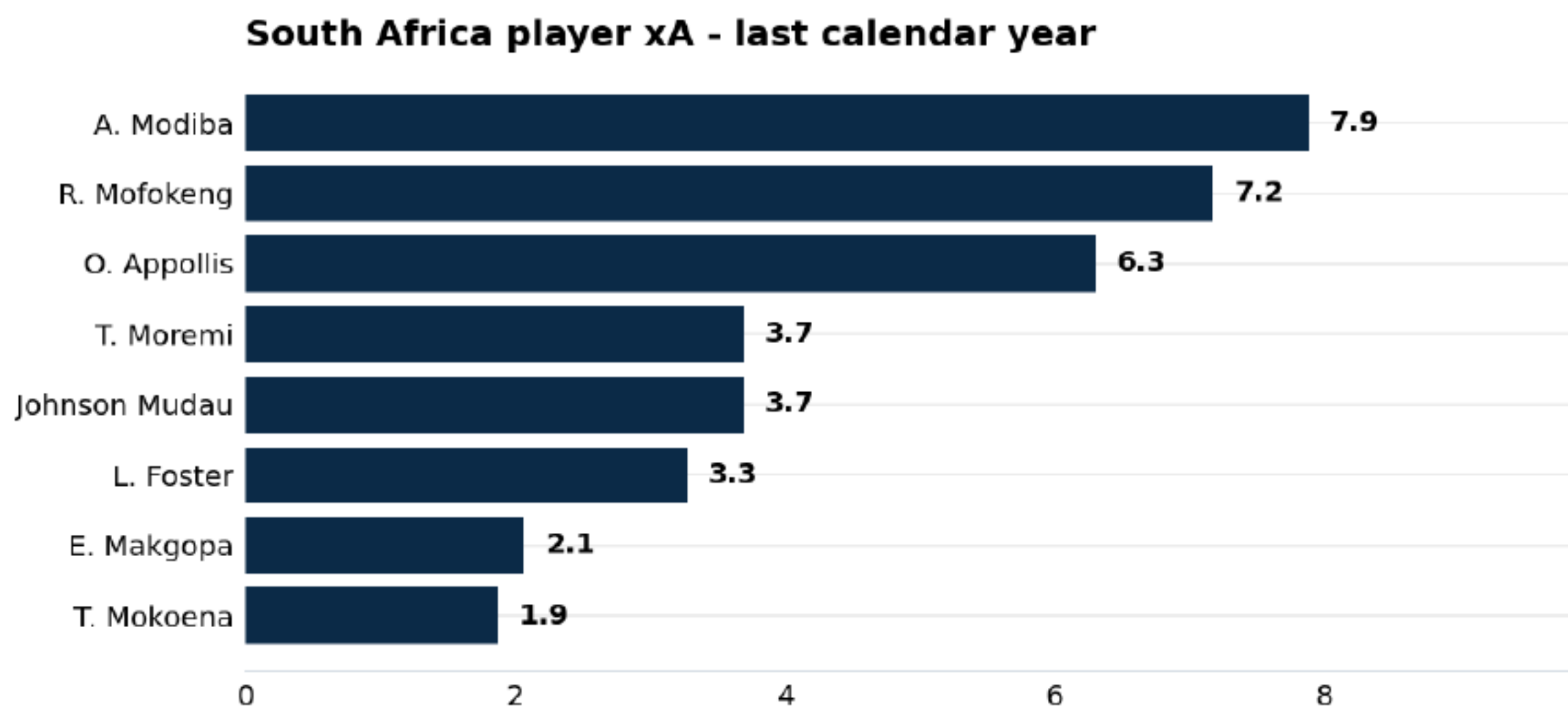
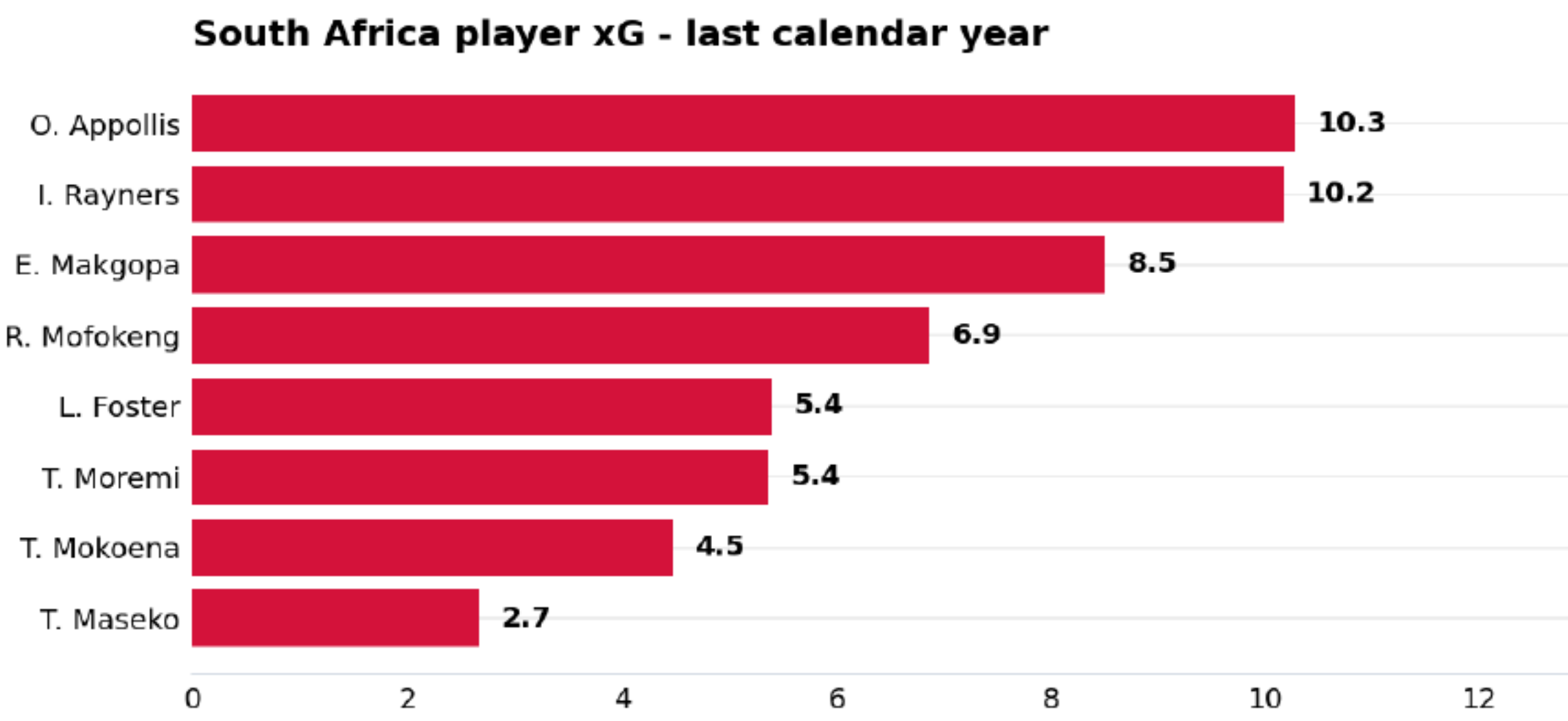


DEFENSIVE MATCHUP READ

- RSA PMSR average: 287 pressures, 39 forced turnovers and 60 second balls.
- The Korea win is the warning sample: lower possession, high pressure/turnover volume and a compact block.
- Canada’s first pass after regain must escape the immediate crowd before the next RSA pressure action.

SOUTH AFRICA PLAYER DATA LAYER

Player-output graphs replace placeholder images: scoring, creation and wide-action samples.



Player	Pos	Age	Min	G	xG	A	xA	ProgR	Drib	Cross
O. Appollis	RAMF, LAMF	24	3074	13	10.27	3	6.30	2.46	3.54	2.20
I. Rayners	CF	30	2058	13	10.17	3	1.66	0.66	0.92	1.01
R. Mofokeng	AMF, LAMF	21	2469	10	6.87	6	7.17	2.33	2.81	2.04
E. Makgopa	CF	26	1453	8	8.51	2	2.06	0.50	1.18	0.56
T. Mokoena	LDMF, DMF, RDMF	29	4129	7	4.47	2	1.87	0.87	0.85	0.98
L. Foster	CF	25	2342	6	5.39	4	3.27	1.19	1.38	0.42
T. Moremi	LAMF, RAMF	25	1894	6	5.37	6	3.69	3.09	3.61	4.18
T. Maseko	RAMF, RWF, CF	22	1212	4	2.67	1	0.69	2.75	3.56	1.04
I. Okon	LCB, RCB	22	2317	2	1.42	0	0.13	1.28	0.43	0.04
A. Modiba	LB	30	3819	1	2.07	7	7.88	2.43	2.14	3.23

ROLE-BASED CANADA READ

Mofokeng

KEY ROLE
between-line creator; Canada screen before pressing wide

Appollis

KEY ROLE
wide/inside scorer; do not allow open-field carries

Maseko

KEY ROLE
transition outlet; control first duel and cover behind

Modiba / Mudau

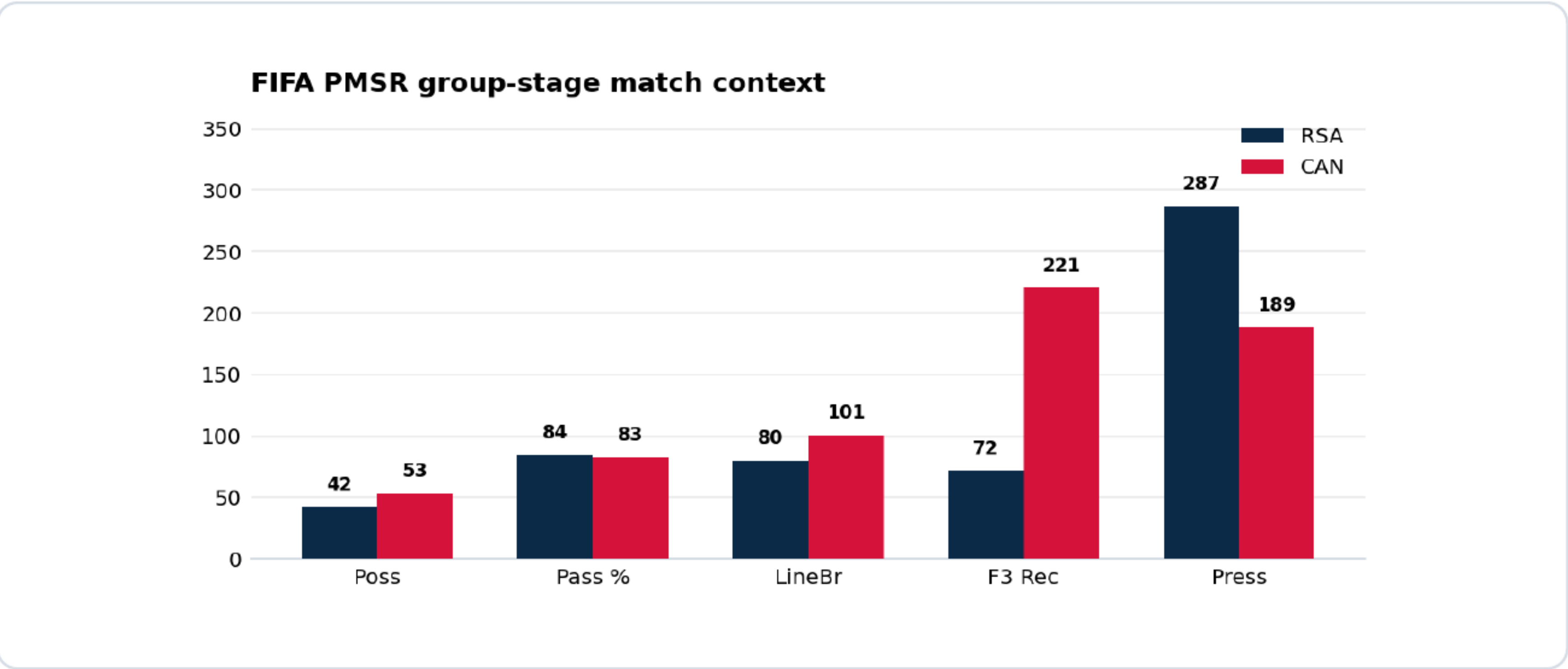
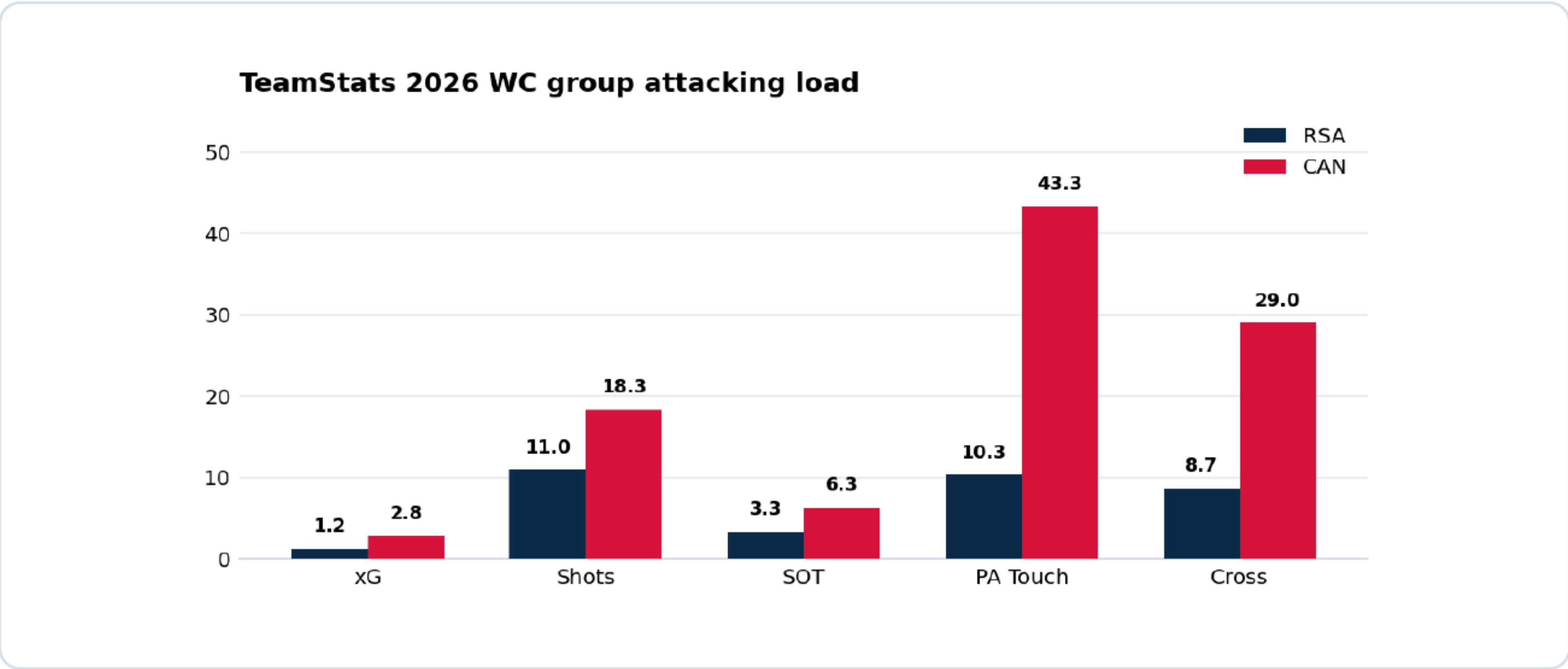
KEY ROLE
full-back delivery; force service from deeper zones

Makgopa / Rayners / Foster

KEY ROLE
box targets; centre-backs must control first contact and second balls

CANADA DATA MATCHUP

Canada metrics are used where they change the South Africa match plan: width, second balls and box pressure.



Matchup	Data point	Canada action
Canada wide service	39.0 PMSR crosses	stress RSA full-backs before block settles
Canada second balls	82.3 PMSR second balls	turn direct play into controlled pressure
RSA pressure	287 PMSR pressures	avoid central slow passes after regain
RSA low block risk	19 low-block phases	Canada must create cutbacks and second actions, not just crosses
RSA PPDA	21.3 TeamStats WC	expect deeper defending than some prior Canada matches

BEST CANADA ROUTES

- Quick switches before South Africa’s compact side-shift arrives.
- Buchanan/Laryea speed into the wide channels, with David close to receive.
- Second ball control after direct service into Larin/Makgopa-type duels.
- Avoid turnovers inside where Mofokeng can start transition.

MATCHUP SUMMARY

Canada should not just chase possession dominance. The data points to fast first passes, wide speed, cross/cutback variety and second-ball control as the practical route to attack South Africa without feeding their transition game.

CANADA MATCH PLAN

Final coaching sheet using the expanded statistical sample and the playing-style visuals.

1. OUT OF POSSESSION

- Screen Mofokeng first; press wide second.
- Use compact central spacing to remove the short triangle shown in RSA build-up frames.
- When RSA circulate slowly, trigger pressure on the receiving full-back, not the first centre-back pass.

2. IN POSSESSION

- First pass after regain must be secure and forward/wide.
- Attack full-back channels before RSA's midfield block is set.
- Use David between lines and Larin as a pinning/second-ball target.

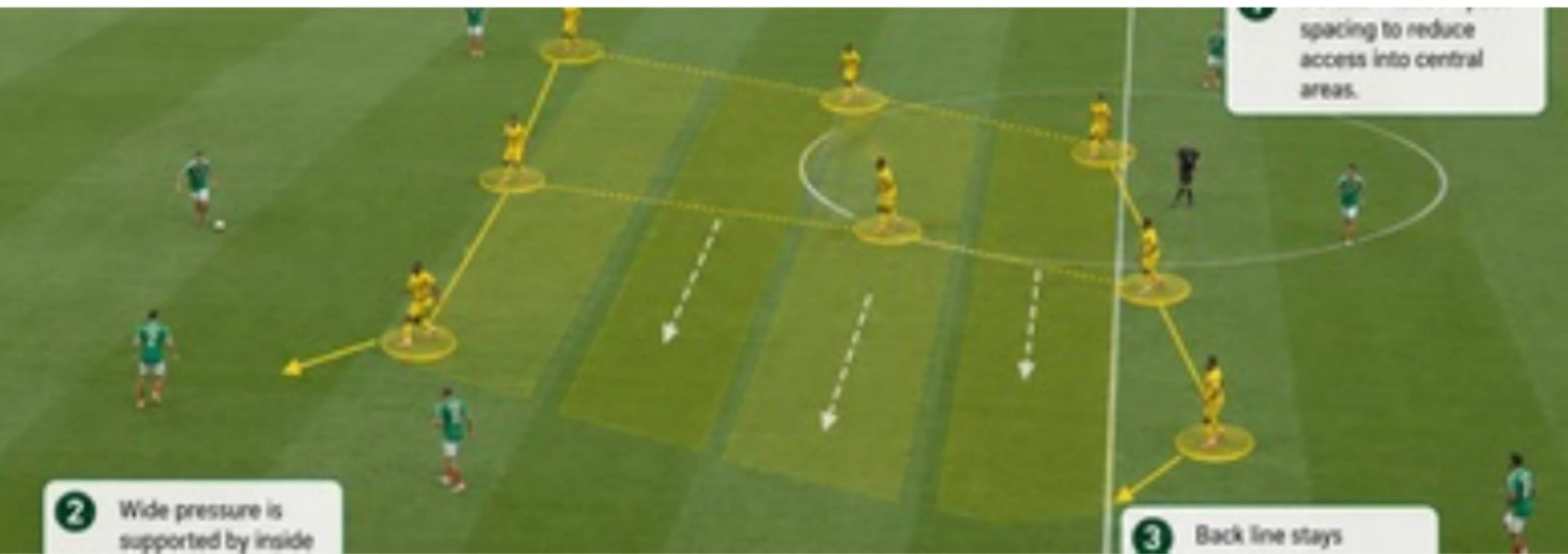
3. BOX & SET PLAYS

- Own first contact on crosses and second balls.
- Protect cutback lane and far-post runner after wide service.
- Do not leave rest defence exposed against Appollis/Maseko release.

4. KEY MATCHUPS

- Johnston/Buchanan vs Maseko/Modiba.
- Laryea/Ali Ahmed vs Appollis/Mudau.
- Eustaquio/Saliba vs Mofokeng/Mbatha/Sithole.

MATCH PLAN IN ACTION



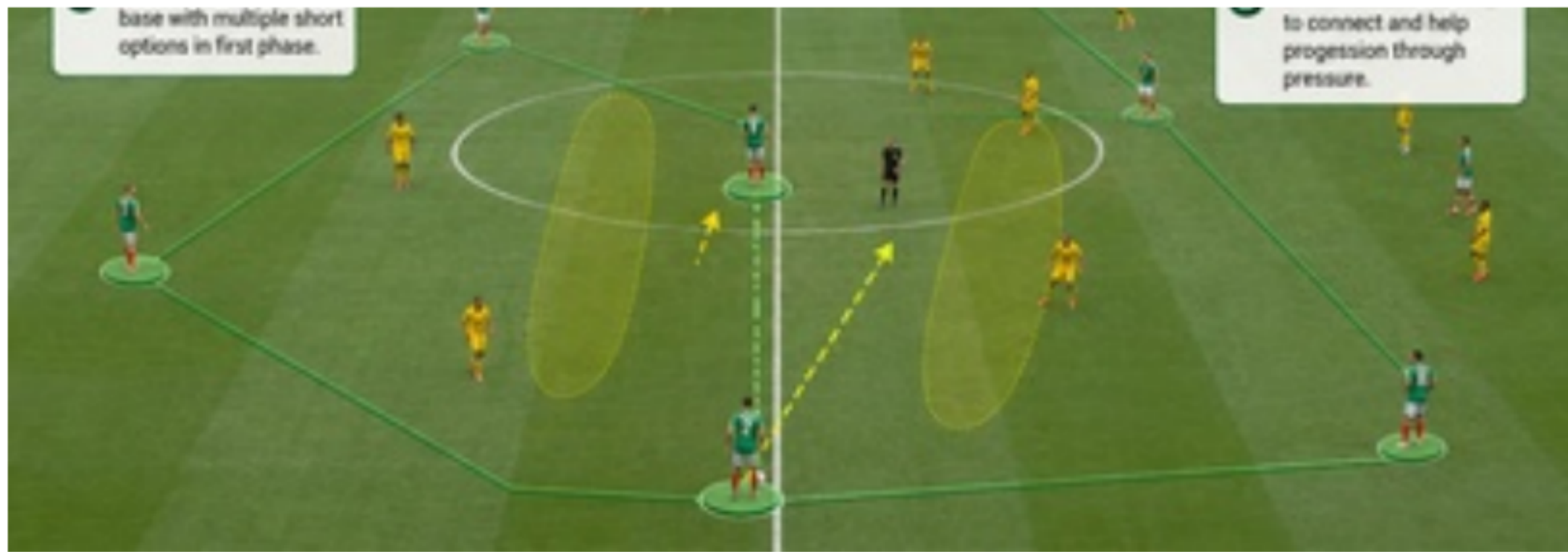
STAY COMPACT

Do not over-chase the first circulation. Force play wide and manage the next pass.



STOP TRANSITION RELEASE

Immediate counter-pressure after Canada losses; do not allow Mofokeng/Appollis to face forward.



ATTACK QUICKLY

Canada's wide speed and first forward pass can break RSA before the block sets.

WINNING CONDITIONS

- 1

Central screen
- 2

Secure first pass
- 3

Wide-speed release
- 4

Cutback defence
- 5

Second-ball control